ENTREPRENEURSHIP · UNIQUE MARKETING ISSUES

Found, chosen, booked.

How an entrepreneurial firm finds its customers, and how its customers find it, when an AI does the searching.

Abdulla Muiz Fuad
Teaching demonstration · MNU Business School

BY THE END OF TODAY YOU CAN…

Four questions every new venture must answer

1

Who?

Segment the market, pick a target, own a unique position

2

Why us?

Define a brand and explain why it matters to a start-up

3

What & how?

Use the 4Ps: product, price, promotion, place

4

Closing the deal

Walk through the seven-step sales process

Our case

Ruka Maldives, Dhiffushi: a real 12-room guesthouse, opened 2025, with no website of its own. Can travellers, and their AI assistants, find it?

YOUR TURN · 90 SECONDS

Be the traveller



abdullamuizfuad.github.io/GEO-Visibility-/demo

1. Scan the code with your camera
2. Pick the traveller you are
3. Watch the AI choose your guesthouse
4. Look for Ruka...

Stop at “Why do you think the AI left Ruka out?”

WHAT JUST HAPPENED?

Hundreds of guesthouses. The AI shows three.



> **“Fewer opportunities to appear, but more impact if you do.”**
>
> Morand & Schegg (2026), *Be Visible to AI*

Why wasn’t Ruka chosen?

Turn to your neighbour: one reason, 15 seconds.

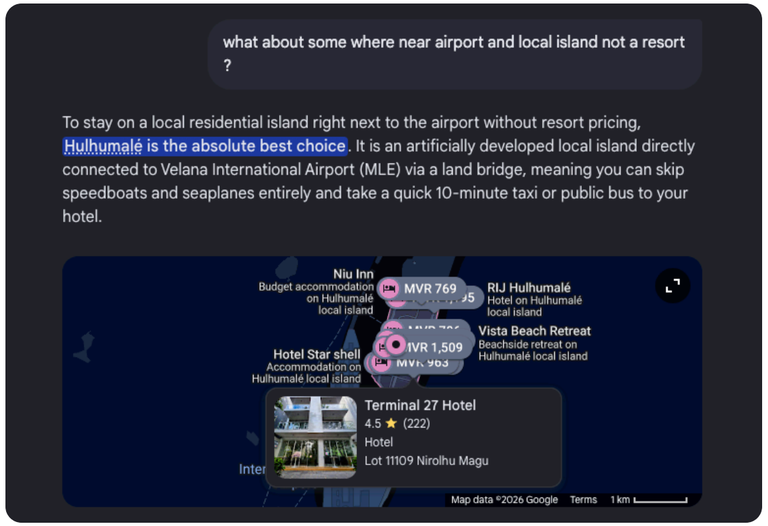
THIS IS NOT HYPOTHETICAL · TESTED 4 NOV 2026

Same questions, real AI engines

Baidu · in Chinese · “We're a couple... not a resort, near the beach”



Google AI Mode · “near the airport, local island, not a resort”



GEMINI · GOOGLE AI MODE · BAIDU
ENGLISH & 中文

Arena Beach Hotel: Baidu’s #1 for couples, and Gemini’s pick for families

Dhiffushi recommended, but the guesthouse named was **Athiri Residence**

Google’s picks all carry a **rating, map pin & website**

0 **times Ruka Maldives was named**

OBJECTIVE 1 · IDENTIFYING CUSTOMERS

Segment → Target → Position

STEP 1 · SEGMENT

Who could stay?

Study the market and split it into groups with shared needs.

- Divers
- Families
- Beach & kite lovers
- Honeymooners
- Budget couples

STEP 2 · TARGET

Who do we serve best?

Choose a narrower group you can win and keep.

- Beach & kite-loving couples
- mid-budget, near Malé

STEP 3 · POSITION

Why us, not them?

A clear, unique place in the customer's mind.

"The small, quiet beach guesthouse on Dhiffushi, steps from the sand."

AI LENS An AI matches the traveller's **intent** to your position, so it must be **specific, provable and repeated everywhere**.

OBJECTIVE 2 · BRAND

A brand is a promise people can recognise

A brand is the set of attributes, positive or negative, that people associate with a company.

Barringer & Ireland, *Entrepreneurship*

- Builds **trust** when you have no track record
- Makes you **different** from look-alike competitors
- Supports a **better price** and repeat visits
- Lets people **and AI** recognise you as one business

EVERYWHERE

Ruka Maldives

Same name · same address · same phone

✔ **All reviews now count for one brand**

Teaching scenario: a typical small-guesthouse problem

OBJECTIVE 3 · MARKETING MIX

The 4Ps, through Ruka’s eyes

P Product

What guests actually get, described so it can be checked.

12 rooms · steps from the beach · 10 min to Kite Beach · breakfast included

P Price

Cost-based (cost + margin) or **value-based** (what guests will pay). Publish a clear range and cancellation policy.

P Promotion

Reviews, social media, word of mouth, and now being **chosen by AI answer engines** (GEO), not only ranked by Google.

P Place

Direct (own site, phone) vs **intermediaries** (Booking.com, agents). AI assistants are becoming a new channel.

OBJECTIVE 4 · SELLING

The seven-step sales process

1

Prospect for leads

Find likely guests

AI helps

2

Initial contact

First impression

AI helps

3

Qualify the lead

Right needs, budget, dates?

AI helps

4

Sales presentation

Show the fit

AI helps

5

Meet objections

“Is it safe for kids?”

You

6

Close the sale

Confirm the booking

You

7

Follow-up

Review, return, refer

You

DISCUSS Which steps does the AI now do for Ruka, and which still need a human?

YOUR TURN · PART 2

Make Ruka visible

BRAND One name, address and phone

PRODUCT Facts, not adjectives

PRICE A clear range + cancellation

PLACE A bookable channel

AI visibility **Strong**

Traveller: a beach-loving couple

1. **Ruka Maldives**
2. Stone Hotels Dhiffushi
3. Arena Beach Hotel

HOW I'D ASSESS THIS

From remembering to doing

UNDERSTAND

Exit ticket

End of today's class

"In one sentence: what is Ruka's position, and could an AI verify it?"

Formative · 2 minutes · instant feedback

APPLY

Exam question

Short answer · 10 marks

"Using a Maldivian guesthouse, explain the seven-step sales process and which steps AI assistants now influence."

Summative · tests all four outcomes

ANALYSE · CREATE

AI visibility audit

Group assignment

Audit a real local guesthouse across AI assistants, Google and Booking.com, then recommend its target, position, brand and 4Ps.

Rubric: diagnosis 30 · recommendations 50 · pitch 20

WRAP-UP

Found, chosen, booked.

1. Segment, target and own a **specific** position
2. A brand is trust, recognisable **everywhere**
3. 4Ps: facts, clear price, smart channels
4. Seven steps: AI opens doors, **you** close

MY TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

Students learn marketing best by doing it, on real, local problems, so I teach theory through live cases, questions and tools they can use.

Questions?

SOURCES

References

Barringer, B. R., & Ireland, R. D. *Entrepreneurship: Successfully launching new ventures*. Pearson. Chapter: Unique marketing issues.

Morand, J.-C., & Schegg, R. (2026). *Be visible to AI: The keys to semantic optimization and GEO for hotels* [White paper]. HES-SO Valais-Wallis. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19109201

Aggarwal, P., et al. (2024). GEO: Generative engine optimization. *Proceedings of the 30th ACM SIGKDD Conference*.

Ruka Maldives is used with the owner’s permission. Ruka, Stone Hotels Dhiffushi, Reveries Diving Village and Arena Beach Hotel are described only with publicly listed facts; the “before” problems are a teaching scenario. The demo is a scripted simulation, not a live AI.